

SQL LIKE Operator & Wildcards

Searching for partial text patterns, wildcard symbols, and high-yield exam rules

1. What are Wildcards?

The **LIKE** operator is used in a **WHERE** clause to search for a specified pattern in a column when exact values are unknown.

%

Percent Symbol

Represents **any number of characters**, including zero characters.

_

Underscore Symbol

Represents **exactly one single character** at a fixed position.

2. Standard Query Patterns

Starts with 'A'

```
SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE name LIKE 'A%';
```

First char must be **A**; anything after.
Matches: Arun, Amrit, Ajeet

Ends with 'N'

```
SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE name LIKE '%N';
```

Last char must be **N**; anything before.
Matches: Varun, Arun

Contains 'EE' anywhere

```
SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE name LIKE '%EE%';
```

The substring **EE** must occur anywhere in the name. Characters before and after can be anything.

3. Positional Pattern Breakdowns

Pattern 1: Second character is 'A' (_A%)

```
SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE name LIKE '_A%';
```

_ → Exactly 1 first character | **A** → Second character must be **A** | % → Any number of remaining characters
(e.g., VARUN)

Pattern 2: Second character is 'A' AND total length is exactly 5 (_A___)

```
SELECT * FROM Emp WHERE name LIKE '_A___';
```

_ (1st char) + **A** (2nd char) + _ _ _ (3 remaining chars) = 1 + 1 + 3 = **Exactly 5 characters**